

History of Fashion – Exam Revision Notes

1. Fashion Evolution and Its Influence on Kenyan Fashion Trends

Fashion evolution refers to changes in clothing styles over time due to social, cultural, economic, political, and technological influences. Kenyan fashion has evolved from traditional attire to modern styles influenced by urbanization, globalization, technology, and local creativity.

2. Traditional Clothing in Kenya

Traditional clothing reflects cultural identity, age, gender, and social status. Examples include Maasai shukas and beadwork, Kikuyu traditional garments, Luo attire and ornaments, and Kalenjin hides and beadwork.

3. Colonial Influence on Kenyan Fashion

British colonial rule introduced Western styles such as suits, dresses, shirts, trousers, and school uniforms. Missionaries promoted modest dress. New fabrics and tailoring techniques were introduced, though some traditional dress practices declined.

4. Globalization and Contemporary Kenyan Fashion

Globalization has increased access to international trends through media, technology, and trade. Contemporary Kenyan fashion blends African heritage with global influences and often incorporates Kitege, Ankara, and Maasai-inspired designs.

5. Influence of Youth Culture and Urban Life

Youth culture drives trends through music, celebrities, social media, and entertainment. Urban centers such as Nairobi encourage streetwear, thrift fashion (mitumba), and fusion styles.

Major Fashion Eras

Ancient Egypt

General: Linen, hot climate, status through dress. Women: Fitted linen dresses and jewelry. Men: Kilts and simple draped garments.

Ancient Greece

General: Simplicity and draping. Women: Chiton and peplos. Men: Tunics and cloaks.

Roman Era

General: Status-conscious fashion. Women: Stola and shawls. Men: Tunics and togas.

Medieval Era

General: Modesty and class distinction. Women: Long gowns and veils. Men: Tunics, hose, and cloaks.

Renaissance Era

General: Luxury and ornamentation. Women: Corseted bodices and full skirts. Men: Doublets and decorative garments.

Victorian Era

General: Formality and modesty. Women: Corsets, bustles, full skirts. Men: Three-piece suits and top hats.

1920s

General: Freedom and modernity. Women: Flapper dresses. Men: Tailored suits and fedoras.

1950s

General: Elegance and prosperity. Women: Full skirts and fitted waists. Men: Conservative suits.

1960s

General: Youth culture and experimentation. Women: Mini skirts. Men: Slim-fit suits.

1970s

General: Self-expression. Women: Maxi dresses and bell-bottoms. Men: Flared trousers and patterned shirts.

1980s

General: Bold styles. Women: Power suits and shoulder pads. Men: Power dressing and athletic wear.

1990s

General: Casual fashion. Women: Denim and crop tops. Men: Baggy jeans and sneakers.

Contemporary Era

General: Globalized fashion, sustainability, technology. Women and Men: Streetwear, athleisure, and blended traditional-modern styles.

Additional Exam Topics

Factors Influencing Fashion

Social, cultural, political, economic, and technological factors.

Functions of Clothing

Protection, modesty, identification, status, and decoration.

Fashion Terminology

Fashion, style, trend, fad, classic, haute couture, and ready-to-wear.

Industrial Revolution

Mass production, textile factories, sewing machines, and cheaper clothing.

African Fashion and Textiles

Kitenge, Ankara, Kanga, and Maasai fabrics characterized by vibrant colors and symbolism.

Sustainable Fashion

Recycling, upcycling, ethical production, and eco-friendly materials.

Fashion Cycle

Introduction → Rise → Peak → Decline → Obsolescence.